**METRIC**

**A-A-20210A**
**June 13, 2001**
**SUPERSEDING**
**A-A-20210**
**May 2, 1997**

# COMMERCIAL ITEM DESCRIPTION

# SALSA, TOMATO-BASED

**The U.S. Department of Agriculture has authorized the use of this Commercial Item Description.**

**1. SCOPE.** This Commercial Item Description (CID) covers tomato-based salsa (salsa) packed in commercially acceptable containers, suitable for use by the Federal, State, local governments, and other interested parties.

## 2. PURCHASER NOTES.

### 2.1 Purchasers *shall specify* the following:

- Type(s), pungency(ies), and style(s) required (Sec. 3).
- When analytical requirements are different than specified (Sec. 6.1).
- When analytical requirements need to be verified (Sec. 6.2).
- Manufacturer's/distributor's certification (Sec. 9.2) or USDA certification (Sec. 9.3).

### 2.2 Purchasers *may specify* the following:

- Define pungency requirements through a bid sample (Sec. 6.1.2).
- Manufacturer's quality assurance (Sec. 9.1 with 9.1.1) or (Sec. 9.1 with 9.1.2).
- Packaging requirements other than commercial (Sec. 10).

**3. CLASSIFICATION.** The salsa shall conform to the following list which shall be specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order.

**Types, pungencies, and styles.**

**Type I** – Shelf stable (cooked)
**Type II** – Fresh, perishable (uncooked)

**FSC 8950**

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T08:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

**Pungency A** – Extra mild
**Pungency B** – Mild
**Pungency C** – Medium
**Pungency D** – Hot

**Style 1** – Regular
**Style 2** – Chunky

**4. MANUFACTURER'S/DISTRIBUTOR'S NOTES. Manufacturer's/distributor's products *shall meet* the requirements of the:**

- Salient characteristics (Sec. 5).
- Analytical requirements: *as specified by the purchaser* (Sec. 6).
- Manufacturer's/distributor's product assurance (Sec. 7).
- Regulatory requirements (Sec. 8).
- Quality assurance provisions: *as specified by the purchaser* (Sec. 9).
- Packaging requirements other than commercial: *as specified by the purchaser* (Sec. 10).

**5. SALIENT CHARACTERISTICS.**

**5.1 Processing.** The salsa shall be prepared in accordance with good commercial practice (21 CFR Part 110). Type I, shelf stable salsa shall be packed in hermetically sealed containers and shall be sufficiently processed by heat to assure adequate sterilization.

**5.2 Ingredients.** The salsa shall include tomatoes and/or tomato puree, onions, peppers (ex: chili, jalapeño, green bell, red bell, yellow bell, etc.), garlic, salt, and vinegar and/or citric acid, and/or phosphoric acid added to the adjust the pH. The salsa may include; but not limited to: water, onion powder, garlic powder, tomato powder, sugar, corn syrup, chili puree, jalapeño puree, pepper, carrots, corn, cilantro, red pepper powder, cumin, oregano, natural flavors, lime juice, and lemon juice. The salsa may also include processing ingredients such as, but not limited to: calcium chloride, xanthan gum, modified food starch, potassium sorbate, sodium benzoate, and propionic acid.

**5.2.1 Tomatoes.** Tomatoes in Style 1, regular salsa, shall be discernible fine pieces. The tomatoes in Style 2, chunky salsa, shall be discernible coarse pieces. The tomatoes may or may not be peeled.

**5.2.2 Onions.** For Style 1, regular salsa, the onions shall be discernible fine pieces. For Style 2, chunky salsa, the onions shall be discernible coarse pieces.



Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T08:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

**5.3 Optional processing ingredients.**

**5.3.1 Calcium chloride.** Calcium chloride shall be of Food Chemicals Codex purity. Calcium chloride may be added as a processing aid to maintain the structural rigidity of the diced tomatoes.

**5.3.2 Thickeners.** The salsa may include thickeners such as but not limited to: xanthan gum or modified starch to increase or aid the viscosity.

**5.3.3 Preservatives.** The salsa may include preservatives such as but not limited to: potassium sorbate, sodium benzoate, and propionic acid to prevent yeast, mold and bacteria growth. The preservatives shall be of Food Chemicals Codex purity.

**5.4 Finished product.**

**5.4.1 Flavor and odor.** The salsa shall be slightly acidic and have the odor and flavor of tomatoes with spices and peppers. The salsa shall be free from off flavors and odors, with no bitter, burnt, sour, or excessively hot taste.

**5.4.2 Appearance.** The salsa shall have a red color with discernible pieces of tomato, onion, and peppers. Style B, chunky salsa shall have a rich thick texture.

**5.4.3 Drained weight and washed drained weight.** Type I, shelf stable (cooked) salsa shall meet one of the following requirements.

**5.4.3.1 Drained weight.** The drained weight for Type I, shelf stable (cooked), Style 1, regular salsa shall be 45-55 percent and for Type I, shelf stable (cooked), Style 2, chunky salsa shall be 55- 80 percent.

**Procedure:** Place the salsa product at room temperature atop a 12 inch diameter U.S. Standard No. 8 sieve in a manner that will distribute the product over the sieve. Drain for 2 minutes at approximately a 20 degree angle. Determine drained weight by subtracting the sieve tare weight from the gross weight. Report the solids and juice as a percentage of the whole. The drained weight shall be reported to the nearest whole percentage.

**5.4.3.2 Washed drained weight.** The washed drained weight for Type I, shelf stable (cooked), Style 1, regular salsa shall be 20-35 percent and for Type I, shelf stable (cooked), Style 2, chunky salsa shall be 35-55 percent.

**Procedure:** Place the salsa product at room temperature atop a 12 inch diameter U.S. Standard No. 8 sieve in a manner that will distribute the product over the sieve. Rinse lightly with 20 to 22$^{o}$C (68 to



Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T08:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

72°F) water until all visible free liquid is removed. The sieve shall be tilted at approximately a 20 degree angle and allowed to drain for 2 minutes before determining drained weight by subtracting the sieve tare weight from the gross weight. The drained weight shall be reported to the nearest whole percentage.

## 6. ANALYTICAL REQUIREMENTS

**6.1 Analytical requirements.** Unless otherwise specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, the analytical requirements for the salsa shall be as follows:

| Test | Requirements |
|---|---|
| pH | 3.8-4.3 |
| Soluble Solids | 8.0 to 11.5 percent |
| Consistency | Type I, Shelf stable, Style A, Regular: Not less than 3.0 or more than 5.5 centimeters in 30 seconds at 20°C (68°F) ± 1°C (1.8°F) |

**6.1.2 Pungency.** When required in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, pungency shall be defined at the discretion of the buyer or be based on a reference or bid sample product and be a mutual agreement between the parties involved. **NOTE:** Commercial vendors pungency ranges vary greatly.

**6.2 Product verification.** When USDA verification of analytical requirements is specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, the following procedures will be followed.

**6.2.1 Sampling procedures.** USDA inspection service will select the number of product containers based on USDA inspection service sampling procedures and plans.

**6.2.2 Composite sample.** Analytical and microbiological testing shall be performed on a composite sample. The composite sample shall be 454 grams (1 pound) and prepared from subsamples drawn from randomly selected containers. The number of subsamples used to create the composite shall be based on USDA procedures.

**6.3 Preparation of sample.** The sample shall be prepared in accordance with the Official Methods of Analysis of the AOAC International Method 945.68.

**6.4 Analytical testing.** When specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, the analyses shall be made in accordance with the following methods from the Official Methods of Analysis of the AOAC International or as specified below:



Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T08:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

| Test | Method |
|---|---|
| pH | 981.12 |
| Pungency | 995.03, ASTA Official Method 21.3 1/ |
| Soluble Solids | 932.12 |
| Consistency | Bostwick Consistometer |

1/ When a pungency range is specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, analysis of pungency shall be tested with the methods indicated above.

**6.5 Test results.** The test results for pH shall be reported the nearest 0.1 unit. The test results for pungency shall be reported to the nearest Scoville unit and/or ppm Capsaicin with one ppm Capsaicin equal to 15 Scoville units. The test results for solids shall be reported to the nearest 0.1 percent. Any result not conforming to the analytical requirements shall be cause for rejection of the lot.

**7. MANUFACTURER'S/DISTRIBUTOR'S PRODUCT ASSURANCE.** The manufacturer/ distributor shall certify that the salsa provided shall meet the salient characteristics of this CID, conform to their own specifications, standards, and quality assurance practices, and be the same prepared salsa offered for sale in the commercial market. The purchaser reserves the right to require proof of conformance.

**8. REGULATORY REQUIREMENTS.** The delivered salsa shall comply with all applicable Federal, State, and local mandatory requirements and regulations relating to the preparation, packaging, labeling, storage, distribution, and sale of salsa within the commercial marketplace. Delivered salsa shall comply with all applicable provisions of the Federal Food, Drug, and Cosmetic Act and regulations promulgated thereunder.

**9. QUALITY ASSURANCE PROVISIONS.** *Purchaser shall specify 9.2 or 9.3; purchaser may specify 9.1 with 9.1.1 or 9.1 with 9.1.2.*

**9.1 Manufacturer's quality assurance.** When required in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, the product manufacturer shall be required to provide evidence, by certificate, that the manufacturing plant has undertaken one of the following quality assurance measures within 12 months prior to providing a bid, or no later than 10 business days from the date of awarding of the contract. Failure to provide this documentation within the proper time frame may result in the contract being terminated for cause.

**9.1.1 Plant systems audit.** A plant systems audit (PSA) conducted by USDA, Agricultural Marketing Service (AMS), or another audit performed by a third party auditing service is required



Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T08:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

within 12 months prior to the date of the awarding of the contract. *(An AMS PSA verifies the manufacturer's capability to produce products in a clean, sanitary environment in accordance with Title 21 Code of Federal Regulations Part 110 - Current Good Manufacturing Practice in Manufacturing, Packing, or Holding Human Food; and verifies that the manufacturer has in place an internal quality assurance program. The AMS PSA determines the manufacturer's ability to produce under this CID, if the products of interest are identified at the time of the PSA.)*

**9.1.2 Plant survey.** A plant survey conducted by USDA, AMS, or another survey performed by a third party auditing service is required within 12 months prior to the date of the awarding of the contract. *(An AMS plant survey audit verifies that, at the time of the survey, the manufacturer produces products in a clean, sanitary environment in accordance with Title 21 Code of Federal Regulations Part 110 - Current Good Manufacturing Practice in Manufacturing, Packing, or Holding Human Food.)*

**9.2 Manufacturer's/distributor's certification.** When required in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, the manufacturer/distributor will certify that the finished salsa distributed meets or exceeds the requirements of this CID.

**9.3 USDA certification.** When required in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order that product quality and acceptability or both be determined, the Processed Products Branch (PPB), Fruit and Vegetable Programs (FVP), AMS, USDA, shall be the certifying program. PPB inspectors shall certify the quality and acceptability of the salsa in accordance with PPB procedures which include selecting random samples of the packaged salsa, evaluating the samples for conformance with the salient characteristics of this CID and other contractual requirements, and documenting the findings on official PPB score sheets and/or certificates. In addition, when required in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, PPB inspectors will examine the salsa for conformance to the United States Standards for Condition of Food Containers in effect on the date of the solicitation.

**10. PACKAGING.** Preservation, packaging, packing, labeling, and case marking shall be commercial unless otherwise specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order.

**11. USDA INSPECTION NOTES. When Section 9.3 is specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, USDA certification shall include evaluation of the quality and condition of samples of packaged salsa, and compliance with requirements in the following areas:**

- Salient characteristics (Sec. 5).
- Analytical requirements *when specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order* (Sec. 6.4). When USDA analytical testing is specified, PPB inspection personnel shall select samples



Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T08:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

and submit them to the USDA, Science and Technology Program (S&TP) laboratory for analysis.

- Packaging requirements (Sec. 10 or as specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order).

**12. REFERENCE NOTES.**

**12.1 USDA certification contact.** For USDA certification, contact the **Branch Chief, PPB, FVP, AMS, USDA, STOP 0247, 1400 Independence Avenue, SW, Washington, DC 20250-0247, telephone (202) 720-4693, Fax (202) 690-1527, or via E-mail: james.rodeheaver@usda.gov.**

**12.2 Analytical testing and technical information.** For USDA technical information on analytical testing, contact the **Branch Chief, Technical Service Branch, S&TP, AMS, USDA, STOP 0272, 1400 Independence Avenue, SW, Washington, DC 20250-0272, telephone (202) 690-0621, or via E-mail: anita.okrend@usda.gov.**

**12.3 Sources of documents.**

**12.3.1 Source of information for nongovernmental document is as follows:**

Copies of the Official Methods of Analysis of the AOAC International may be obtained from: **AOAC International, 481 North Frederick Avenue, Suite 500, Gaithersburg, MD 20877. You may contact AOAC International on (301) 924-7077 or on the Internet at: www.aoac.org.**

Copies of the Food Chemicals Codex may be obtained from: **National Academy Press, 2101 Constitution Avenue, NW, Lockbox 285, Washington, DC 20055, telephone (202) 334-3313, Fax (202) 334-2451, via E-mail: zjones@nas.edu or on the Internet at: www.nap.edu.**

Copies of the ASTA Official Method 21.3 may be obtained from: **American Spice Trade Association, 560 Sylvan Ave., P.O. Box 1267, Englewood Cliffs, NJ 07632. You may contact ASTA on (201) 568-2163, or via E-mail: publications@astaspice.org.**

**12.3.2 Sources of information for governmental documents are as follows:**

Applicable provisions of the Federal Food, Drug, and Cosmetic Act are contained in 21 CFR Parts 1 to 199. This document may be purchased from: **Superintendent of Documents, ATTN: New Orders, P. O. Box 371954, Pittsburgh, PA 15250-7954. Credit Card (MasterCard or VISA) purchases may be made by calling the Superintendent of Documents on (202) 512-1803 or on the Internet at: www.nara.gov/fedreg.**



Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T08:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

Copies of this CID, the United States Standards for Condition of Food Containers, and beneficial comments, recommendations, additions, deletions, clarifications, etc., and any data which may improve this CID are available from and/or provided to: **Head, Food Quality Assurance Staff, FVP, AMS, USDA, STOP 0243, 1400 Independence Ave., SW, Washington, DC**

**20250-0243, telephone (202) 720-9939, Fax (202) 690-0102, via E-mail: FQAStaff@usda.gov or on the Internet at: http://www.ams.usda.gov/fv/fvqual.htm.**

Military activities should submit requests for copies of this CID to: **Standardization Documents Order Desk, Defense Automation and Production Service, 700 Robbins Avenue, Building 4D, Philadelphia, PA 19111-5094.**

**MILITARY INTERESTS:**

**Military Coordinating Activity**

Army - GL

**Custodians**

Army - GL
Navy - SA
Air Force - 35

**Review Activities**

Army - MD, QM
Navy - MC
DLA - SS

**CIVIL AGENCY COORDINATING ACTIVITIES:**

DOJ - BOP
HHS - NIH, IHS
USDA - FV
VA - OSS

**PREPARING ACTIVITY:**

USDA - FV

The U.S. Department of Agriculture (USDA) prohibits discrimination in all its programs and activities on the basis of race, color, national origin, sex, religion, age, disability, political beliefs, sexual orientation, or marital or family status. (Not all prohibited bases apply to all programs.) Persons with disabilities who require alternative means for communication of program information (Braille, large print, audiotape, etc.) should contact USDA's TARGET Center at (202) 720-2600 (voice and TDD).

To file a complaint of discrimination, write USDA, Director, Office of Civil Rights, Room 326-W, Whitten Building, 14th and Independence Avenue, SW, Washington, DC 20250-9410 or call (202) 720-5964 (voice and TDD). USDA is an equal opportunity provider and employer.



Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T08:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.